

# Updated

## PetRescue - interactive data visualisation project brief

|                 |                                   |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------|
| Organisation    | PetRescue                         |
| Contact         | Patima                            |
| Designer        | Jess                              |
| Engagement type | Volunteer / collaborative project |

### Background:

PetRescue is an Australian animal welfare charity organisation on a mission to create a future where every pet is safe, respected and loved. Most known for their pet adoption platform, [www.PetRescue.com.au](http://www.PetRescue.com.au) which reaches approximately 5 million unique visitors each year, their objective is to support the Australian rescue community find homes for every pet, reduce the number of homeless pets, and, ultimately, end the unnecessary killing of healthy and adoptable pets.

PetRescue has supported over 2,000 rescue organisations (827 currently active), providing free rehoming and adoption tools, resources, and platform, which has helped connect more than 1 million pets with loving homes. Simultaneously PetRescue creates sector building resources and programs including facilitating \$15 million+ in food and product donations to rescues, and leveraging data to drive change with their annual State of Pet Adoption Report.

The rescue community comprises shelters, volunteer run foster care networks, vets, and council facilities.

### Problem:

There is no central, authoritative source of data on pet adoption trends in Australia. Different organisations quote different figures for key metrics. (eg. How many pets are killed each year, how many are at risk). PetRescue holds some of the most comprehensive data in the sector, but it is currently represented in a way that limits its reach and usefulness:

- Reports are published as static pages - walls of text, non interactive charts
- The data is hard to consume for advocates, policy makers, journalists and the general public
- There is no way to show insights or explore trends over time
- The data is complex and nuanced. Detailed reports certainly require the depth of insights provided, but become ineffective for consumption due to the volume of insights published.

Media often misrepresents the systemic issues with shallow coverage that is unhelpful to creating long term change (e.g. the pet abandonment rhetoric is often painted with tales of neglectful and irresponsible owners, however, surrendering is often not a choice when people and families are facing chronic distress and financial hardship)

### Users:

Primary: Advocates, policy makers, journalists, and sector organisations (e.g. RSPCA, government bodies) who need credible data to support funding decisions, resource allocation, and advocacy

campaigns.

Secondary: General public interested in rescuing or fostering a pet who want context and to understand the broader picture.

#### User goals:

- To quickly find credible, up-to-date data in an engaging, easy-to-understand format
- To be able to reference and share specific insights (e.g. for a report, a media pitch, a grant application)
- To understand regional need, not just national trends
- To feel connected to the issue, not just informed about it

### **Project goal:**

New: focused interactive visual artefacts that can help better narrate and drive action - drawing on the state of pet adoption report and also external research e.g. able to be used as a reference that can demonstrate the need, and efficacy of progressive preventative and intervention programs (e.g. why targeting cat desexing programs are the gold standard in humanely controlling cat populations, preventing psychosocial hazards for community cat carers and people in the rescue sector, reduces costs for local government, and will ultimately reduce the number of unhoused cats needing homes). All other current alternatives have the opposite intended effects (e.g. untargeted desexing programs, cat trapping and cat culling)

### **Proposed scope (core deliverable):**

The kitty calculator / catscape (or a better name...): An interactive page or narrative data that visually shows the current state of domestic cats in Australia (including pet cats and urban stray cats - **not feral cats**), and allows users to explore community cat population predictions with varied approaches applied in Australia. As these initiatives take 3-4 years to see tangible difference, the visual should show impact over time (population management, local government costs - starting vs ongoing vs all time, distress reduced over time)

- Do nothing
- Outdated cat trapping and culling initiatives
- Desexing programs (untargeted)
- Targeted desexing programs

The comparison (like a race chart) is an important communication tool to show the difference in impact per methods. The data being dynamic is also a must - being able to assess the scale of change and impact based on different starting numbers also matters so that it can be extended for use in analysis and prediction.

Sharing the state snapshot would be a helpful tool (ie save and share to myself as an email, or share via socials or email to networks)

Inspired by examples like the ABC's election coverage: rich, engaging, visually guided.

#### Potential features:

- Trend visualisations. Eg. pet adoption rates over 5, 10, 20 years
- Species breakdown: dogs vs cats vs other animals. How the mix has shifted over time
- Geographic heat map: areas of highest need across Australia, mapped against socio-economic index (SEIFA)

- Advocacy... surfaces insights relevant to government funding and resource allocation.
- Iconographic / "human scale" numbers - eg. how many dogs is that relative to a suburb or city?

## References:

- <https://www.abc.net.au/news/elections>

## Storytelling / visual essay format:

### ABC:

[How life has changed for people your age](#) by ABC News Story Lab (Catherine Hanrahan, Joshua Byrd, Ben Spraggon and Matt Liddy)

[Rich School, Poor School: Australia's Great Education Divide](#) by ABC News Digital Story Innovations team (Inga Ting, Alex Palmer, Nathanael Scott and Ri Liu)

[How hard is it to make a believable deepfake video?](#) by ABC News Story Lab (Tim Leslie, Nathan Hoad, Ben Spraggon and Matt Liddy)

[Counting The Cost Of The Education Revolution](#) by ABC News Digital Story Innovations team (Inga Ting, Ri Liu and Nathanael Scott)

[Super Kamiokande](#) by ABC News Story Lab (Jake Sturmer, Yumi Asada, Ben Spraggon, Colin Gourlay, Josh Byrd, Matt Martino, Cristen Tilley and Matt Liddy)

Australia's growing childcare divide - more static, but nice charts.

<https://www.abc.net.au/news/2024-08-20/mapping-australia-s-growing-childcare-divide/104243302>

### Other:

- The Pudding (pudding.cool). Great examples of how scroll-triggered charts work: <https://pudding.cool>
- The Pudding: "The Unlikely Odds of Making It Big" - scrollytelling with pinned charts and animated data points <https://pudding.cool/2022/07/tiktok-story/>
- Washington Post: 2024 Election county map — interactive dashboard showing county-level voting shifts <https://www.washingtonpost.com/elections/interactive/2024/11/05/compare-2020-2024-presidential-results/>
- "In Pursuit of Democracy" - 145 years of Congressional records turned into a scroll-driven data narrative <https://pudding.cool/2025/11/democracy/>

## Measures of success:

### Proposed metrics

- Increase in time-on-page vs current static report (need current baseline)
- Increase in views per page (need current baseline)
- Increase in external shares (need current baseline + tracking method)
- Qualitative feedback from sector orgs, advocates, journalists who use it - Is this measurable? how do we know this is useful?
- Whether it gets picked up / cited by third parties (e.g. ABC, sector reports, government submissions)

- The signal to success for PetRescue is usage, interest and referencing by external parties. Number of snapshot saves and shares to network. From a mission perspective, it's the uptake of targeted desexing programs and decrease in owned and semi owned cats being needlessly killed.

## Data & assets

Data source: Pet Rescue State of Pet Adoption Report 2023–24 (split across 6 sections: introduction, overview, dogs, cats, other species, and sector overview):

<https://www.petrescue.com.au/the-state-of-pet-adoption-report-2023-2024>

- There are previous years reports too (2021–22, 2022–23)
- I'll provide these ASAP
  - <https://www.petrescue.com.au/library/articles/free-cat-desexing-a-win-for-cats-councils-and-communities>
  - The cat pyramid & PetRescue's Free Living Cat Population Growth.pdf (shows the population multiplier of the absence of desexing programs - e.g. how quickly a single cat and their kittens and impact overall populations)
  - <https://www.petrescue.com.au/library/articles/a-better-way-forward-for-community-cats-in-south-australia>

## Attribution

This is an independent, volunteer-driven project. Attribution for the final work should appear on the page and in any communications, along the lines of:

"Interactive experience designed by Jessica Tong / jesstong.com, in collaboration with PetRescue."

Will require researcher attribution also - we can discuss!

Happy to discuss the exact wording, but would like to be able to reference this publicly as a collaborative piece.

And we should do a feature on you too, if you're happy to be interviewed on the subject of tech for good!

## Ways of working

This is an informal, self-directed project. I'd like to work independently and bring you in at key moments rather than have regular check-ins. Roughly:

- I'll check in with you once I have something concrete to show, or if I hit a blocker with the data
- Ideally one or two feedback touchpoints before anything is published

No expectation of formal project management or regular meetings on either side.

## Questions for Patima:

Data:

1. What data is available beyond what is published in the report? Is there something specific you are seeking?
2. How often is the data collected / updated? (e.g. monthly, annually, ad hoc) real time with a 24

hour lag on some data points - we can extract data at any stage.

3. Should the interactive page be built to accommodate new data being added annually, or is this a one-time snapshot for now? **Dynamic inputs are preferred**
4. How comparable is the data year on year? Have the methodology or categories changed between the 2021-22, 2022-23 and 2023-24 reports in ways that would affect trend lines? **Yes this part is nuanced - especially with the latest data (which is why I'm suggesting we pivot to a concentrated project)**

8. Cats are listed at roughly twice the rate of dogs but receive far fewer enquiries and views. Is this a known problem the sector is actively trying to address, or more a reflection of general public preference? **There are simply more cats - although, cats are (mostly) adopted faster than dogs as there are lower barriers in place.**

Scope:

11. Is there a preference for this living on the Pet Rescue website, or could it be a standalone published page?

**We would want it to be PetRescue branded and hosted, and had envisaged it'd live on a subdomain so we weren't limited by current infrastructure in the build.**

## Free Living Cat Population Growth.

Cat reproduction rates: Re-evaluating the 'million cat pyramid'.

